

The Baby Prep Starter Guide

A calm starting point for registry, gear, and nursery decisions.

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Learn → Plan → Try → Buy

A NOTE FROM TAYLOR

You don't need more information. You need a clearer starting point.

Most expecting parents spend hours in rabbit holes — comparing strollers at 11pm, building registries from influencer lists, and buying things they never end up using. Not because they made bad decisions. Because no one helped them think in the right order.

This guide is not a product list. It is a framework. It will help you slow down, figure out what actually matters for your specific family, and move through the decisions in a sequence that makes sense.

The philosophy behind everything I do is simple:

01

Learn

Understand the category before you evaluate a single product.

02

Plan

Map your home, routine, and budget before you build your list.

03

Try

See gear in person whenever possible. Touch it. Push it. Sit in it.

04

Buy

Purchase with confidence — not because it's trending, but because it fits.

"The goal is not a perfect registry. It is a registry that works for your actual life."

Where to Start (And What to Ignore First)

The most common mistake expecting parents make is starting with products instead of starting with questions. Before you open a single registry or walk into a baby store, answer these five things about your life.

The Five Questions That Shape Everything

Where do you live?

Urban apartment, suburban home, and rural property create completely different gear needs. A stroller that works beautifully in a walkable city may be impractical if you drive everywhere.

What does your typical day look like?

Do you work from home, commute, run errands on foot, or travel frequently? Your daily routine determines which gear you will actually use and which will collect dust.

What is your home like?

Stairs, elevator, narrow hallways, small trunk — these physical constraints eliminate certain gear categories entirely before you compare a single feature.

What is your honest budget?

Not the aspirational budget. The real one. Knowing this early prevents you from falling in love with products that create financial stress before your baby arrives.

What is your biggest anxiety right now?

Car seat safety? Breastfeeding? Sleep setup? Knowing your real worry helps you prioritize where to spend your research energy.

What You Can Safely Ignore for Now

These categories are important but do not belong on your radar in the first planning pass. They create overwhelm without moving you forward:

- Specific product model comparisons (do this after category decisions)
- Registry completion discounts and platform perks (these come last)
- Nursery decor and aesthetic choices (functional setup comes first)
- Baby food, sleep training methods, and postpartum nutrition (these belong in a different phase)
- Gear you won't need until 4+ months (bouncer upgrades, high chairs, activity gyms)

The Big Three: Car Seat, Stroller, Sleep Space

These three decisions carry the most weight, the most confusion, and the most consequence. They also inform each other. Getting clarity here first makes everything else on your registry easier.

Car Seat

Your car seat is not optional. It is also not as complicated as the internet makes it. The decision tree is actually simple:

- Infant car seat: Best for newborns and families who want a travel system. Easier to install and use initially, but your baby will outgrow it in 12–18 months.
- Convertible car seat: Skips the infant seat entirely. Lower upfront cost, longer use. Requires a separate infant carrier for portability.
- All-in-one: Grows from infant through booster. Highest upfront investment, most total value.

The right answer depends on your car, your budget, and how much you will carry the seat. There is no universal best choice.

Stroller

Strollers are the most over-researched, over-purchased category in baby gear. Most families need one stroller. Some need two. Very few need three.

- Full-size / modular: Best for daily use, outdoor terrain, and families who walk a lot. Heavier, larger trunk footprint.
- Compact / lightweight: Best for travel, urban transit, and secondary use. Less suspension, smaller basket.
- Travel system: Infant car seat + stroller frame or compatible full-size stroller. Convenient in the newborn phase.
- Jogging stroller: Only necessary if you actually run. Not a substitute for an everyday stroller.

The stroller decision is almost entirely determined by your answers to the five lifestyle questions on the previous page.

Sleep Space

Your baby will likely sleep in multiple places. That is normal and safe. You do not need to solve 'where will the baby sleep forever' before they arrive.

- Bassinet or bedside sleeper: Most common for the first 3–5 months. Keeps baby close. Many families use this before transitioning to a crib.
- Crib: The long-term solution. Does not need to be used from day one.

- Pack-n-play with bassinet insert: A versatile option that works as a bassinet, travel crib, and play space.

Safe sleep always means: firm flat surface, nothing in the sleep space, on their back. The specific product matters less than how it is used.

Registry: A Framework, Not a List

A registry built from someone else's list will have things that do not fit your life. A registry built from your own lifestyle answers will be smaller, more intentional, and far more useful.

The Registry Timing Sequence

Weeks 16–20

Choose your registry platform(s). Most families use one primary platform. Babylist is the most flexible. Amazon works well for families with Prime. Target is ideal if you plan to shop in store.

Weeks 20–24

Add the Big Three first. Car seat, stroller, sleep space. These anchor the registry and help you see what else you actually need.

Weeks 24–28

Add functional essentials: feeding setup, diapering, bathing, baby-wearing. Use your lifestyle answers to filter recommendations.

Weeks 28–32

Review and edit. Remove duplicates, add items across price points so guests at different budgets can participate, and check for anything that doesn't match your real life.

After showers

Complete what wasn't gifted. Use registry completion discounts strategically.

Registry Mistakes Worth Avoiding

- Registering for multiple versions of the same item “just in case”
- Adding items based on influencer lists without checking fit for your home
- Registering for everything in a category instead of one thoughtful choice per category
- Skipping in-person try before registering for major gear
- Waiting until week 36 to start — you will run out of time and energy

Nursery: Function Before Aesthetics

The nursery can be beautiful. But it needs to be functional first. A well-designed nursery is one where you can do a 2am diaper change without turning on a overhead light, without stubbing your toe, and without waking your baby any more than necessary.

The Functional Nursery Checklist

Prioritize these before decor:

- Safe sleep surface at a comfortable working height
- Changing station with everything within arm's reach (you cannot leave the surface)
- A dim, warm light source for nighttime feeds and changes
- Comfortable seat for feeding — you will spend significant time there
- White noise capability (a \$20 machine works as well as a \$200 one)
- Storage that keeps nighttime essentials accessible and non-nighttime items out of the way

What Can Wait

- Gallery walls and decor (do this after the room is functional)
- Blackout curtains with a valance (the blackout matters, not the aesthetic)
- Coordinated furniture sets (a crib and a dresser do not need to match)
- A dedicated bookshelf (a basket on the floor works fine for the first year)

“Fix the function. Then make it beautiful. In that order.”

NEXT STEPS

Where to Go From Here

This guide is the starting point. It is meant to give you a framework, not to answer every question. The next steps depend on where you are in the process.

If you haven't started yet

Begin with the five lifestyle questions. Write down your answers before you open a single registry or browse a single stroller.

If you have a registry but it feels wrong

Do a five-minute audit: Does each item on the list match your answers to the five lifestyle questions? Remove anything that doesn't.

If you're stuck on one specific decision

Use the TMBC Baby Academy to go deeper on strollers, car seats, nursery planning, or registry strategy — at your own pace.

If you want expert judgment on your specific situation

Book a complimentary 30-minute consultation. Bring your questions, your registry, or just your due date. We'll start wherever you are.

Ready for the next step?

The TMBC Baby Academy walks you through every major category—strollers, car seats, registry, nursery, postpartum—in a calm sequence.

taylormadebabyco.com/academy

Or book a free 30-minute consultation:

taylormadebabyco.com/consultation

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